TALK FOUR

4 To Finish His Work

"My meat is to do the will of him that sent me, and to finish his work."

JOHN 4:34

Samuel the Lamanite had already been thrown out of the Nephites' city when the Lord told him to go back. He had come to tell the people to repent, but they would not listen. As he started home, the Lord told him to return and say whatever He put in Samuel's heart. So Samuel went back. The people would not let him in the gate, so he climbed the city wall and preached from the top.

He told them that in five years the Son of God would be born. The night before, there would be no darkness. People threw stones and shot arrows at Samuel, but they could not hit him. When they sent men to grab him, he jumped down and ran. The Nephites never heard from him again. The Lord sent Samuel back to do a hard thing, and he did it.

When we hear the word Messiah, we often think of someone who saves us. But Messiah and Christ both mean "the Anointed One." In Israel, anointing set a person apart for a work. Saving us was the work Jesus was anointed to do. Once, when His disciples asked Him to eat, He told them, "My meat is to do the will of him that sent me, and to finish his work." Doing His Father's work was what fed Him. Samuel had a part in that work. Jesus asks something of us too. How do we answer when He calls?

Sometimes we push away help because we think we are protecting ourselves. That happened in Jesus's own town. One day at church, He read a prophecy about the Anointed One. Then He told the people it had come true that day. He was the Anointed One, and He had fulfilled it. At first they were pleased. They had heard about the miracles He did in another town, and they wanted Him to bless them the same way. After all, He was one of them.

They wanted Him to perform miracles, but instead Jesus answered with two stories from their scriptures. Once, during a famine, there were many widows in Israel, but the Lord sent His prophet to help a widow from another country. Another time, there were many lepers in Israel, but the only one healed was a man from Syria. Growing up next to Jesus did not mean His neighbors were owed His blessings. He came to bless the humble. In both stories, the Lord passed by His own people to help outsiders who were humble enough to receive His prophets. The people were furious. They took Jesus to the edge of a cliff to throw Him off, but He slipped away. Samuel's story shows us another side of this. The Lord sent a Lamanite, an outsider, to the Nephites. The people who had the scriptures would not let him in the gate.

I wonder if we would have done any better. If someone I had known my whole life stood up at church and said he was called and anointed to a work, I'm not sure what I would do. We have seen this among us. When a man is called to be an apostle, some who grew up with him find it hard to believe. They remember him as a neighbor or a classmate. Some have even left the Work over it. Jesus said that a prophet is honored everywhere except in his own home town. The people in His town were asked to believe, and they would not. We can push away help too, especially when taking it means we have to change. We may want the Lord's help but struggle when He asks us to give up something we have been holding onto.

Samuel's prophecy asked something of the believers too. For five years they waited for the sign. The people who did not believe made fun of them. They set a day to kill everyone who still believed if the sign had not come. Before that day, the Lord told His prophet that He would come into the world the next day. The sign came that night.

Jesus invites all of us into His work. He said, "Take my yoke upon you." A yoke is a wooden bar that joins two animals so they can pull together. He offers us a place beside Him. But to take His yoke, we have to be willing to set down our own. We may not be called to climb a city wall. Still, there are things the Lord asks us to do with the lives He has given us.

A calling asks us to give things up, and it can bring hard things. But there is no good in suffering we are not called to. At Easter, some people carry

wooden crosses along the road Jesus may have walked to His death. A few men even have themselves nailed to crosses. Brother Hammon teaches that this suffering does nothing. The Savior's suffering redeemed us, because He was anointed to do it. He was the Messiah. The hard things on the path the Lord gives us will purify us and make us holy. They are made to fit us, and they build the person He wants us to become. It was Samuel's wall to climb.

The Lord has said that He is the Messiah, and whoever comes in at the gate and climbs up by Him "shall never fall." He was anointed to a work, and He finished it so that we could come in. After one day with Jesus, Andrew went to find his brother and tell him the good news. That is what I want to do with what I have been given.

MY TESTIMONY

I believe that Jesus Christ is our Savior and that His gospel can guide our lives. I believe that God has called the Priesthood Council to teach us the truth and principles of His gospel. When I faced challenges in certain relationships in my life, I prayed for guidance and understanding. As things unfolded, I felt the Holy Ghost guiding me and helping me find peace. This experience strengthened my faith and reminded me that Heavenly Father hears our prayers and guides us through the Holy Ghost, even when the way forward is unclear. I know that as we trust in Him, He will lead us according to His will. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

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